**Checkpoints.** Hugging Face revisions: Qwen2.5-7B-Instruct `a09a35458c70`, Qwen2.5-14B-Instruct `cf98f3b3bbb4`, Qwen2.5-32B-Instruct `5ede1c97bbab`, Mistral-7B-Instruct-v0.3 `c170c708c41d`, Phi-3.5-mini-instruct `2fe192450127`, Qwen3.8-27B `37561816e66b`, Gemma-4-31B-it `842da3794eaa`.

**Generation budget.** The no-marker run and every spacing $k \geq 2$ share one budget, $1.5N+20$ new tokens; $k = 1$ uses $2N + 20$. To check that the budget does not drive any effect, we re-tokenized every stored raw output of the seven open models ($N \leq 64$; 86,400 generations) and counted those that used the whole budget while giving fewer than $N$ answer characters on the first line. Raw generations are stored for every spaced-letter and digit control run, every Qwen3.8 and Gemma 4 run, and the later Qwen2.5-32B batches. The original contiguous-letter and dependency grids of the five earlier models (Qwen2.5-7B, 14B, and the first 32B batch, Mistral, and Phi) predate raw-generation logging and retain only the clipped answer, which is why some marker-compliance entries elsewhere are unavailable. This is an upper bound on cut-off answers, because it also counts short answers followed by unrequested text. The share is 0.58% without markers, 0.49% at $k \geq 2$, and 0.31% at $k = 1$; at the four stronger models it is 0.04%, 0.02%, and 0%. Nearly all cases are Phi-3.5-mini on spaced letters (up to 19% of one cell without markers, against 14% with), and on the dependency tasks the share is 0.03% or less in every class.

## C How the uncertainty was computed

Pooled effects use the length-matched estimator of Section 3, with analytic standard errors over generations. Two checks ask how much that choice matters (`scripts/analyze_statistics_robustness.py`; per-cell values in `results_clean/_summary/statistics_robustness.csv`). Both resample 2,000 times, over the 91 pooled task–model cells of the three position-local families and the dependency family.

**Resampling generations reproduces the analytic result.** Bootstrapping generations within each condition and length gives a median $|z|$ within 3% of the analytic value, and the Bonferroni verdict ($|z| \geq 3.51$) changes in 1 of 91 cells. The analytic standard errors are therefore not the weak point.

**Resampling whole cells is far wider.** Treating each (length, spacing, alphabet) cell as the unit instead, so that whole cells enter or leave a resample, widens the median interval from 0.046 to 0.155 and leaves 17 of 91 cells above the Bonferroni threshold instead of 62. Two things drive this, and neither is a defect in the data. First, a pooled cell deliberately spans lengths at which the effect is absent: at $N \leq 16$ these models are near ceiling and markers do nothing, which is itself Finding 2. Averaging those in and then asking how much the average moves when lengths are resampled mostly measures that by-design heterogeneity. Second, a pooled cell contains only 10 to 25 (length, spacing, alphabet) cells, and a bootstrap over so few clusters has little power.

Restricting to the length where the claim is actually made removes the first problem. At $N = 64$, all 24 spaced-letter and digit cells at the four stronger models have a positive effect, between +0.07 and +0.37 (mean +0.24); all 24 clear $|z| \geq 3.51$ analytically and under the generation bootstrap, 22 of 24 have a cell-level $|z| \geq 2$, and 4 of 24 clear 3.51 under the cell-level bootstrap with its 15 or so clusters (`results_clean/_summary/finding2_at_N64.csv`).

We therefore read a pooled $z$ as a statement about the mean effect over the grid we ran, not as evidence that the effect is uniform across lengths and spacings, nor that it would survive a different choice of grid. The claims about structure rest on the length-resolved and position-resolved analyses (Figures 4 and 3), not on the pooled numbers.

**The baseline's marker sentence.** The no-marker prompt keeps the sentence that describes the markers. To measure what that costs, we reran the no-marker condition at the four stronger models with every mention of markers removed from the prompt, on the same inputs (`scripts/run_clean_baseline.py`): the ten task variants of the two tokenization controls and the dependency family, $N \in \{16, 32, 64\}$, every alphabet or modulus value, 20 trials. Table 8 gives the paired difference (clean minus with-sentence) per model and family. It is +0.006 overall (95% interval $[0.002, 0.009]$ over 300 cells), between −0.015 and +0.026 in every model–family combination, and negative, meaning the sentence helped, in 105 of the 300 cells. Recomputing

Finding 2 at $N = 64$ against the clean baseline moves the share of remaining errors removed by at most 0.014 at any model.

Table 8: Cost of the baseline's marker sentence: no-marker accuracy with the sentence removed minus with it present, on the same inputs, mean over (task, length, alphabet) cells with a 95% interval over cells. $N \in \{16, 32, 64\}$, 20 trials per cell.

| Model | Spaced letters | Digits | Dependency | All |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Qwen2.5 14B | $+0.011 \pm 0.006$ | $+0.005 \pm 0.007$ | $-0.015 \pm 0.015$ | $+0.002 \pm 0.006$ |
| Qwen2.5 32B | $-0.002 \pm 0.009$ | $-0.002 \pm 0.010$ | $+0.015 \pm 0.011$ | $+0.003 \pm 0.006$ |
| Qwen3.8 27B | $-0.009 \pm 0.022$ | $+0.017 \pm 0.013$ | $+0.014 \pm 0.011$ | $+0.007 \pm 0.010$ |
| Gemma 4 31B | $+0.007 \pm 0.010$ | $+0.005 \pm 0.010$ | $+0.026 \pm 0.013$ | $+0.012 \pm 0.007$ |
| All | | | | $+0.006 \pm 0.004$ |

**Dropping the redundant configurations.** At $A = 2$ the three position-local rules coincide and at $M = 2$ `running_sum_local` computes `running_xor` (Section 3). Recomputing all 91 pooled cells without those configurations moves the effect by 0.013 in the median cell and at most 0.054; the effect gets *larger* in 54 of 91 cells, because the two-symbol cells are the easiest and dilute the average. Three cells change sign, all with $|\Delta| \leq 0.009$ and none significant either way, and the Bonferroni verdict changes in 5 of 91 cells. Finding 2 is unchanged: 23 of its 24 cells remain significant.

## D Per-model results

Figures 7 and 8 show accuracy by sequence length for each open model and task; Gemini is in Table 15. Pooled effects and their significance are in Figure 5.

**Mistral-7B.** In all three position-local tasks, the benefit is largest at short lengths and decays to zero at the longest length tested (`cyclic_shift`, $N = 256$: $+0.008$, $z = 0.4$; `random_permutation`, $N = 64$: $-0.009$, $z = 0.5$; `conditional_shift`, $N = 64$: $-0.006$, $z = 0.4$). In Qwen models the benefit holds or grows with length.

**Repetition collapse.** On `running_xor`, Qwen2.5-7B repeats a single wrong digit in about 38% of trials, more often under dense markers. This failure falls to 0.9% at 14B and 0.1% for Mistral-7B, so it is specific to Qwen2.5-7B.

**Out-of-alphabet answers.** On the digit tasks, Qwen2.5-7B often writes a letter (usually `t`, sometimes `o`) in place of `0`, in 34% to 39% of outputs, with or without markers. On spaced letters, several models step outside the alphabet (for example `I` after `H` instead of wrapping to `A`). Such characters are scored as errors.

## E Per-position accuracy

Table 9 gives the per-position means plotted in Figure 3, and Table 10 breaks them down by distance from the marker. Table 11 repeats the dependency-task comparison under alignment-robust scoring, Table 12 repeats it at $k = 2$, 3, and 4 separately, and Figure 9 shows the length profile of the tokenization controls for each task. "No markers" is the no-marker run's accuracy at the same position indices. Means are over the tasks in each block; per-task values are in `results_clean/_summary/per_position_values.csv`.

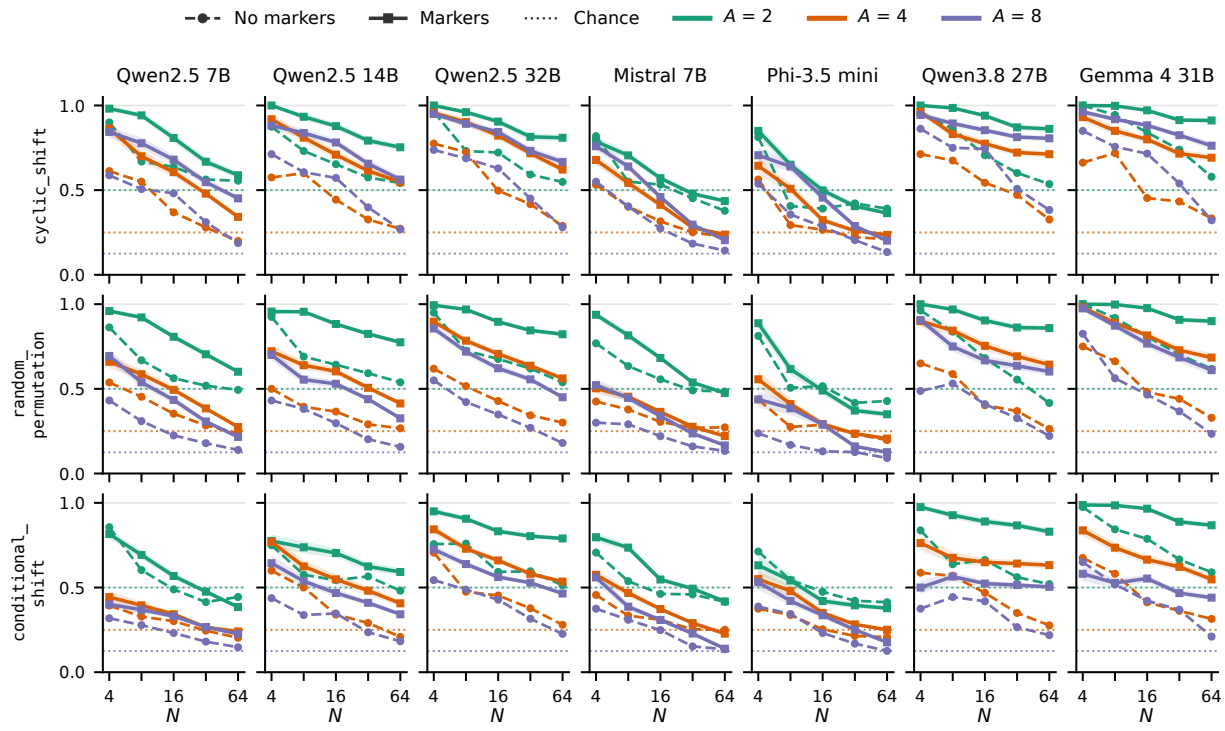



Figure 7: Position-local tasks on contiguous letters, by model and length. Character accuracy against sequence length $N$ (4 to 64). Dashed: no markers; solid: markers (mean over spacings $k \in \{1, 2, 4, 8, 16\}$ with $k < N$); colors: alphabet size; dotted: chance; bands: $\pm 1$ standard error.

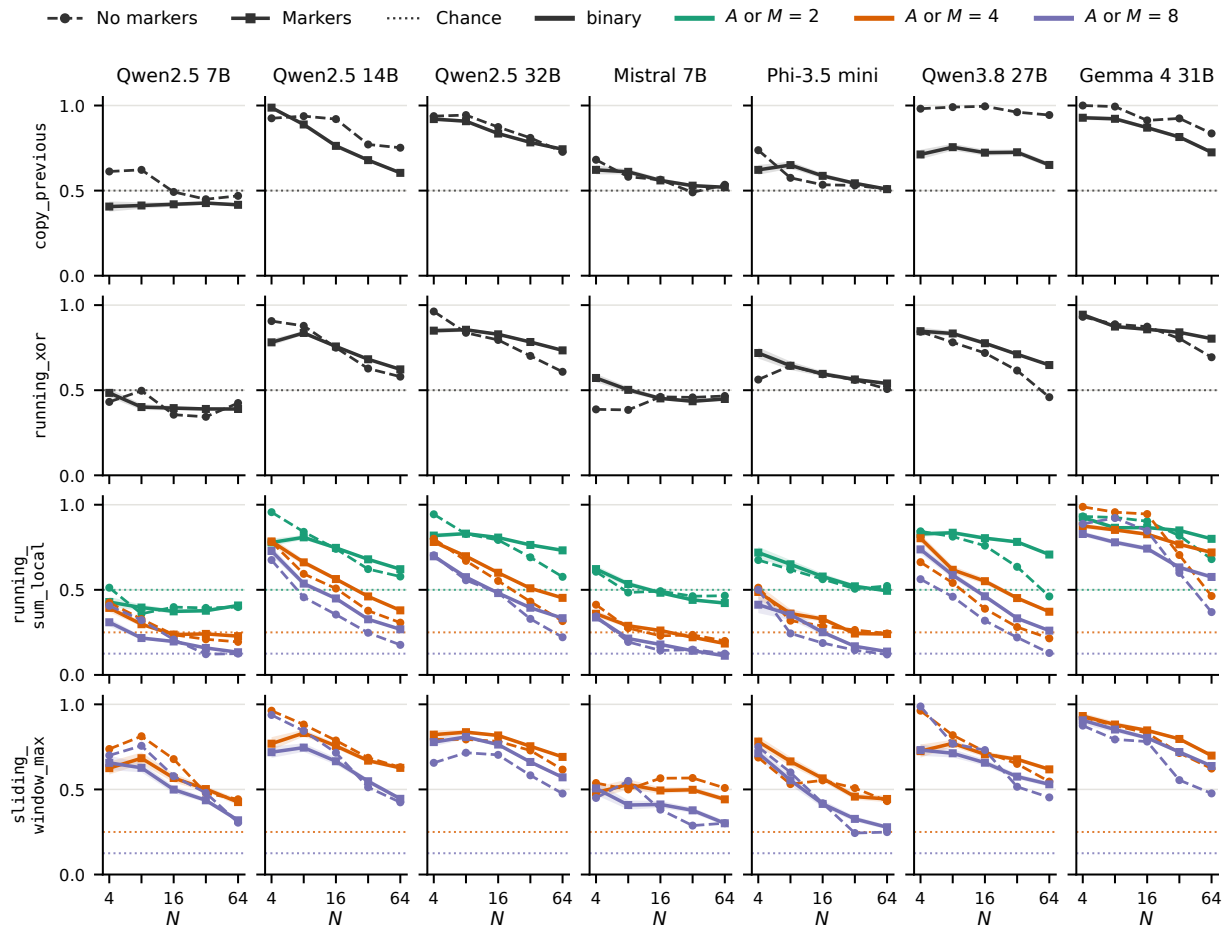



Figure 8: Dependency tasks (digits), by model and length; same conventions as Figure 7. Colors: modulus (`running_sum_local`) or alphabet size (`sliding_window_max`); black: binary. Marker runs average over all positions, so they mix the post-marker loss with the within-segment gain (Section 6).

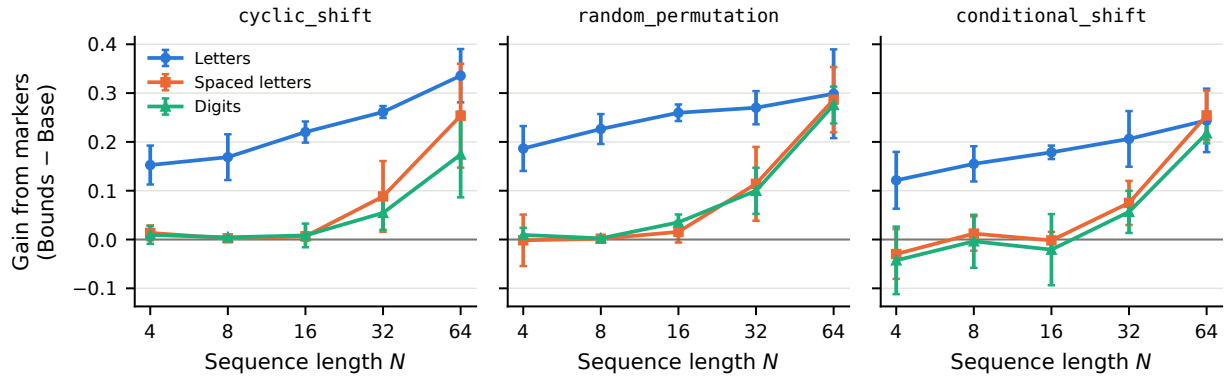



Figure 9: The length profile of Figure 4a, task by task (mean over Qwen2.5-14B and 32B, Qwen3.8-27B, and Gemma-4-31B; whiskers are 95% intervals over models). All three tasks show the same pattern.

Table 9: Per-position accuracy by model ($N \leq 64$, $k \in \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$), mean over the tasks in each block.

| | Within a segment | | | Right after a marker | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Model | No markers | Markers | Δ | No markers | Markers | Δ |
| *Position-local tasks, letters* | | | | | | |
| Qwen2.5 7B | 0.38 | 0.45 | +0.07 | 0.37 | 0.51 | +0.14 |
| Qwen2.5 14B | 0.43 | 0.55 | +0.11 | 0.40 | 0.63 | +0.23 |
| Qwen2.5 32B | 0.49 | 0.65 | +0.16 | 0.45 | 0.79 | +0.34 |
| Mistral 7B | 0.35 | 0.35 | 0.00 | 0.30 | 0.39 | +0.09 |
| Phi-3.5 mini | 0.31 | 0.31 | 0.00 | 0.28 | 0.35 | +0.07 |
| Qwen3.8 27B | 0.50 | 0.69 | +0.20 | 0.47 | 0.81 | +0.34 |
| Gemma 4 31B | 0.56 | 0.72 | +0.16 | 0.51 | 0.80 | +0.29 |
| Gemini 3.5 Flash | 0.57 | 0.74 | +0.17 | 0.52 | 0.83 | +0.32 |
| *Position-local tasks, spaced letters* | | | | | | |
| Qwen2.5 7B | 0.54 | 0.55 | +0.01 | 0.52 | 0.52 | 0.00 |
| Qwen2.5 14B | 0.69 | 0.80 | +0.11 | 0.67 | 0.82 | +0.15 |
| Qwen2.5 32B | 0.79 | 0.93 | +0.14 | 0.79 | 0.92 | +0.14 |
| Mistral 7B | 0.40 | 0.43 | +0.03 | 0.35 | 0.45 | +0.09 |
| Phi-3.5 mini | 0.35 | 0.35 | −0.01 | 0.33 | 0.34 | +0.01 |
| Qwen3.8 27B | 0.83 | 0.92 | +0.09 | 0.84 | 0.92 | +0.08 |
| Gemma 4 31B | 0.88 | 0.94 | +0.06 | 0.89 | 0.94 | +0.05 |
| *Position-local tasks, digits* | | | | | | |
| Qwen2.5 7B | 0.35 | 0.38 | +0.04 | 0.30 | 0.35 | +0.05 |
| Qwen2.5 14B | 0.77 | 0.85 | +0.08 | 0.77 | 0.87 | +0.09 |
| Qwen2.5 32B | 0.83 | 0.94 | +0.11 | 0.83 | 0.93 | +0.09 |
| Mistral 7B | 0.43 | 0.38 | −0.04 | 0.41 | 0.39 | −0.02 |
| Phi-3.5 mini | 0.48 | 0.55 | +0.07 | 0.44 | 0.56 | +0.12 |
| Qwen3.8 27B | 0.85 | 0.94 | +0.09 | 0.85 | 0.94 | +0.09 |
| Gemma 4 31B | 0.92 | 0.99 | +0.07 | 0.92 | 0.98 | +0.06 |
| *Dependency tasks* | | | | | | |
| Qwen2.5 7B | 0.43 | 0.41 | −0.02 | 0.42 | 0.36 | −0.06 |
| Qwen2.5 14B | 0.68 | 0.68 | 0.00 | 0.64 | 0.49 | −0.15 |
| Qwen2.5 32B | 0.70 | 0.77 | +0.07 | 0.66 | 0.52 | −0.15 |
| Mistral 7B | 0.44 | 0.43 | 0.00 | 0.43 | 0.38 | −0.04 |
| Phi-3.5 mini | 0.49 | 0.48 | 0.00 | 0.45 | 0.42 | −0.03 |
| Qwen3.8 27B | 0.68 | 0.70 | +0.02 | 0.63 | 0.44 | −0.19 |
| Gemma 4 31B | 0.79 | 0.85 | +0.05 | 0.78 | 0.52 | −0.26 |
| Gemini 3.5 Flash | 0.92 | 0.97 | +0.05 | 0.92 | 0.49 | −0.43 |
| *Dependency tasks, reset variants* | | | | | | |
| Qwen2.5 7B | 0.43 | 0.43 | 0.00 | 0.41 | 0.58 | +0.17 |
| Qwen2.5 32B | 0.69 | 0.79 | +0.10 | 0.65 | 0.92 | +0.27 |
| Qwen3.8 27B | 0.66 | 0.68 | +0.03 | 0.63 | 0.98 | +0.36 |
| Gemma 4 31B | 0.77 | 0.85 | +0.08 | 0.75 | 0.97 | +0.22 |

Table 10: Accuracy by distance after the marker at $k = 16$ ($N \in \{32, 64\}$): 0 is the position right after the marker. Mean over the tasks in each block.

| | | Positions after the marker | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Tasks | Model | 0 | 1 | 2–3 | 4–7 | 8–15 |
| Position-local, letters | Qwen2.5 7B | 0.32 | 0.38 | 0.35 | 0.29 | 0.26 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | 0.45 | 0.47 | 0.41 | 0.37 | 0.34 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | 0.60 | 0.57 | 0.48 | 0.45 | 0.41 |
| | Mistral 7B | 0.28 | 0.34 | 0.29 | 0.26 | 0.25 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | 0.30 | 0.28 | 0.28 | 0.28 | 0.23 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.68 | 0.67 | 0.59 | 0.51 | 0.47 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.52 | 0.62 | 0.55 | 0.51 | 0.43 |
| | Gemini 3.5 Flash | 0.74 | 0.69 | 0.65 | 0.51 | 0.46 |
| Position-local, spaced | Qwen2.5 7B | 0.30 | 0.46 | 0.47 | 0.43 | 0.35 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | 0.59 | 0.67 | 0.68 | 0.66 | 0.59 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | 0.86 | 0.90 | 0.89 | 0.88 | 0.85 |
| | Mistral 7B | 0.31 | 0.39 | 0.37 | 0.27 | 0.24 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | 0.25 | 0.37 | 0.33 | 0.25 | 0.21 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.89 | 0.88 | 0.91 | 0.91 | 0.90 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.93 | 0.94 | 0.95 | 0.93 | 0.94 |
| Position-local, digits | Qwen2.5 7B | 0.28 | 0.38 | 0.32 | 0.30 | 0.25 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | 0.83 | 0.85 | 0.86 | 0.81 | 0.76 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | 0.90 | 0.93 | 0.94 | 0.93 | 0.90 |
| | Mistral 7B | 0.31 | 0.38 | 0.36 | 0.31 | 0.26 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | 0.38 | 0.53 | 0.52 | 0.46 | 0.37 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.90 | 0.89 | 0.91 | 0.91 | 0.90 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.94 | 0.98 | 0.99 | 0.98 | 0.98 |
| Dependency | Qwen2.5 7B | 0.36 | 0.41 | 0.42 | 0.42 | 0.36 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | 0.45 | 0.75 | 0.68 | 0.60 | 0.53 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | 0.49 | 0.85 | 0.79 | 0.71 | 0.63 |
| | Mistral 7B | 0.41 | 0.42 | 0.45 | 0.42 | 0.41 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | 0.40 | 0.47 | 0.44 | 0.40 | 0.38 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.46 | 0.70 | 0.71 | 0.65 | 0.58 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.49 | 0.82 | 0.83 | 0.81 | 0.75 |
| | Gemini 3.5 Flash | 0.57 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 1.00 | 0.97 |

Table 11: Per-position gains on dependency tasks (marker run minus the no-marker run at the same positions) under index-by-index scoring and under edit-distance alignment, which repairs dropped or inserted characters. $N \leq 64$, $k \in \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$.

| | | Right after a marker | | Within a segment | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | Model | Index | Aligned | Index | Aligned |
| `copy_previous` | Qwen2.5 7B | −0.10 | −0.09 | −0.07 | −0.06 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.21 | −0.15 | −0.10 | −0.05 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.15 | −0.17 | −0.02 | −0.02 |
| | Mistral 7B | −0.05 | −0.01 | 0.00 | +0.01 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | −0.04 | −0.07 | −0.01 | −0.04 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.45 | −0.20 | −0.24 | −0.05 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.29 | −0.25 | −0.07 | −0.04 |
| `running_xor` | Qwen2.5 7B | +0.02 | −0.02 | +0.01 | 0.00 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.14 | −0.13 | +0.05 | +0.01 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.19 | −0.24 | +0.11 | +0.03 |
| | Mistral 7B | −0.04 | −0.03 | +0.02 | −0.03 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | −0.05 | −0.02 | +0.03 | +0.03 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.06 | −0.08 | +0.13 | +0.06 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.26 | −0.29 | +0.09 | +0.04 |
| `running_sum_local` | Qwen2.5 7B | −0.03 | −0.04 | −0.01 | −0.02 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.08 | −0.12 | +0.07 | +0.03 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.16 | −0.22 | +0.11 | +0.05 |
| | Mistral 7B | −0.01 | −0.04 | 0.00 | −0.01 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | −0.03 | 0.00 | −0.02 | −0.03 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.06 | −0.13 | +0.14 | +0.09 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.41 | −0.46 | +0.11 | +0.07 |
| `sliding_window_max` | Qwen2.5 7B | −0.11 | −0.06 | −0.02 | −0.02 |
| | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.16 | −0.10 | −0.03 | −0.01 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.09 | −0.07 | +0.08 | +0.07 |
| | Mistral 7B | −0.07 | 0.00 | −0.02 | 0.00 |
| | Phi-3.5 mini | +0.02 | −0.03 | −0.02 | −0.03 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.18 | −0.16 | +0.05 | +0.04 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.07 | −0.08 | +0.08 | +0.02 |

Table 12: The blind spot at $k = 2$, 3, and 4 separately (dependency tasks, four stronger models, $N \leq 64$): change at the post-marker and within-segment positions against the no-marker run at the same positions. $k = 3$ is otherwise excluded from the pooled analyses.

| | | Post-marker change | | | Within-segment change | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | Model | $k = 2$ | $k = 3$ | $k = 4$ | $k = 2$ | $k = 3$ | $k = 4$ |
| `copy_previous` | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.19 | −0.18 | −0.25 | −0.14 | −0.13 | −0.10 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.16 | −0.12 | −0.18 | −0.13 | −0.05 | −0.01 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.47 | −0.41 | −0.43 | −0.33 | −0.25 | −0.21 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.33 | −0.26 | −0.26 | −0.10 | −0.10 | −0.09 |
| `running_xor` | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.17 | −0.20 | −0.13 | −0.02 | +0.08 | +0.09 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.22 | −0.20 | −0.19 | +0.09 | +0.12 | +0.14 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.07 | −0.14 | −0.10 | +0.06 | +0.11 | +0.18 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.27 | −0.28 | −0.28 | +0.11 | +0.10 | +0.10 |
| `running_sum_local` | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.10 | −0.17 | −0.10 | +0.01 | +0.12 | +0.14 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.20 | −0.20 | −0.17 | +0.12 | +0.09 | +0.12 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.09 | −0.17 | −0.09 | +0.12 | +0.15 | +0.15 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | −0.43 | −0.47 | −0.45 | +0.06 | +0.08 | +0.12 |
| `sliding_window_max` | Qwen2.5 14B | −0.23 | −0.18 | −0.16 | −0.11 | −0.11 | +0.00 |
| | Qwen2.5 32B | −0.02 | −0.04 | −0.11 | +0.08 | +0.11 | +0.10 |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | −0.22 | −0.25 | −0.20 | −0.01 | +0.10 | +0.13 |
| | Gemma 4 31B | +0.01 | +0.12 | −0.14 | +0.11 | +0.04 | +0.04 |

## F Reset variants, pooled

Table 13 gives the pooled effect of markers on each dependency task in its original and reset forms; the per-position comparison is in Section 6.1.

Table 13: Reset variants, pooled over positions: Character accuracy Base → Bounds, Δ, and $|z|$, pooled as in Figure 5 (no-marker mean length-matched). Base differs between the original and reset columns because the reset prompt alone shifts no-marker accuracy; Section 6.1 therefore compares marker runs position by position. Originals use 20 to 80 trials per cell (Table 7); reset variants 20, except 80 at Qwen2.5-7B.

| | | Original (dependency intact) | | Reset (dependency severed) | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | Model | Base→Bounds | Δ ($\lvert z\rvert$) | Base→Bounds | Δ ($\lvert z\rvert$) |
| `running_xor` | 7B | 0.401→0.403 | +0.002 (0.1) | 0.450→0.482 | +0.032 (3.4) |
| | 32B | 0.746→0.798 | +0.053 (6.2) | 0.715→0.878 | +0.163 (11.9) |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.646→0.742 | +0.096 (9.5) | 0.645→0.855 | +0.210 (14.4) |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.816→0.850 | +0.034 (4.3) | 0.816→0.928 | +0.112 (10.2) |
| `running_sum_local` | 7B | 0.286→0.280 | −0.006 (0.8) | 0.277→0.348 | +0.071 (12.4) |
| | 32B | 0.547→0.603 | +0.056 (9.0) | 0.508→0.660 | +0.152 (12.1) |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.441→0.573 | +0.131 (13.0) | 0.419→0.683 | +0.264 (19.4) |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.754→0.775 | +0.021 (3.2) | 0.723→0.840 | +0.117 (10.8) |
| `sliding_window_max` | 32B | 0.668→0.733 | +0.065 (7.9) | 0.677→0.816 | +0.139 (10.9) |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.666→0.653 | −0.013 (1.0) | 0.640→0.824 | +0.183 (16.4) |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.708→0.783 | +0.075 (6.3) | 0.718→0.817 | +0.099 (7.9) |
| `copy_previous` | 7B | 0.508→0.418 | −0.090 (7.0) | 0.565→0.553 | −0.013 (1.4) |
| | 32B | 0.836→0.818 | −0.018 (1.9) | 0.874→0.792 | −0.083 (4.6) |
| | Qwen3.8 27B | 0.971→0.709 | −0.262 (23.9) | 0.942→0.836 | −0.105 (6.4) |
| | Gemma 4 31B | 0.917→0.832 | −0.086 (6.5) | 0.837→0.866 | +0.029 (1.3) |

## G External tasks

Tables 14 and 15 and Figures 10 and 11 give the results on tasks we did not design (Section 6) and on Gemini.

Table 14: External position-local tasks, pooled across length and density. Base: no-marker accuracy averaged over lengths. Best-$k$: accuracy at the single best spacing (optimistic). $\Delta$: marker runs minus the length-matched no-marker mean (Section 3). ProcBench-Substitute was regenerated after we made the vendored ProcBench generator's substitution table deterministic (it was drawn in a process-dependent order).

| | Qwen2.5-7B | | | Qwen2.5-32B | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | Base | Best-$k$ | $\Delta$ ($\lvert z\rvert$) | Base | Best-$k$ | $\Delta$ ($\lvert z\rvert$) |
| Vowel/consonant tagging | 0.438 | 0.435 | −0.083 (2.4) | 0.615 | 0.657 | +0.012 (0.5) |
| ProcBench-Substitute | 0.189 | 0.432 | +0.096 (6.7) | 0.390 | 0.757 | +0.203 (10.8) |
| String copying | 0.973 | 1.000 | +0.009 (1.0) | 0.993 | 1.000 | +0.007 (2.0) |

Table 15: Closed-model check and CLRS-Text. Gemini 3.5 Flash with 3 trials per cell, pooled over all tested lengths (including $N$ up to 256 for `cyclic_shift`), with the no-marker mean length-matched. CLRS-Text tasks use token-level markers and scoring.

| Task | Model | Base acc. | Bounds acc. | $\Delta$ ($\lvert z\rvert$) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| `cyclic_shift` | Gemini | 0.596 | 0.852 | +0.256 (14.4) |
| `random_permutation` | Gemini | 0.561 | 0.846 | +0.284 (8.4) |
| `conditional_shift` | Gemini | 0.453 | 0.628 | +0.175 (3.1) |
| `running_xor` | Gemini | 0.882 | 0.913 | +0.032 (0.4) |
| `running_sum_local` | Gemini | 0.918 | 0.803 | −0.116 (5.2) |
| `copy_previous` | Gemini | 0.984 | 0.924 | −0.060 (2.8) |
| CLRS minimum | Qwen2.5-7B | 0.133 | 0.183 | +0.050 (3.3) |
| | Qwen2.5-32B | 0.592 | 0.392 | −0.200 (4.5) |
| | Gemini | 0.997 | 0.654 | −0.343 (7.3) |
| CLRS Kadane | Qwen2.5-7B | 0.060 | 0.068 | +0.008 (1.0) |
| | Qwen2.5-32B | 0.186 | 0.122 | −0.064 (2.0) |
| | Gemini | 0.384 | 0.354 | −0.030 (0.3) |

On Kadane's algorithm, base accuracy at both Qwen scales is statistically indistinguishable from chance under a shuffle test, so we do not interpret its effects. Minimum is well above chance at Qwen2.5-32B ($z = 4.1$ from shuffled chance).

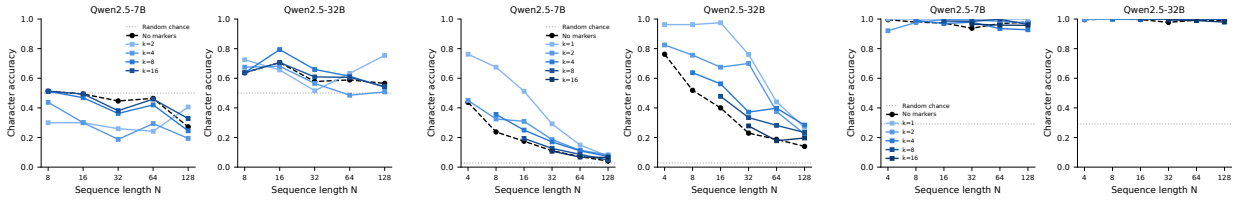



Figure 10: External tasks by marker density. Left: vowel/consonant tagging. Middle: ProcBench-Substitute. Right: string copying.

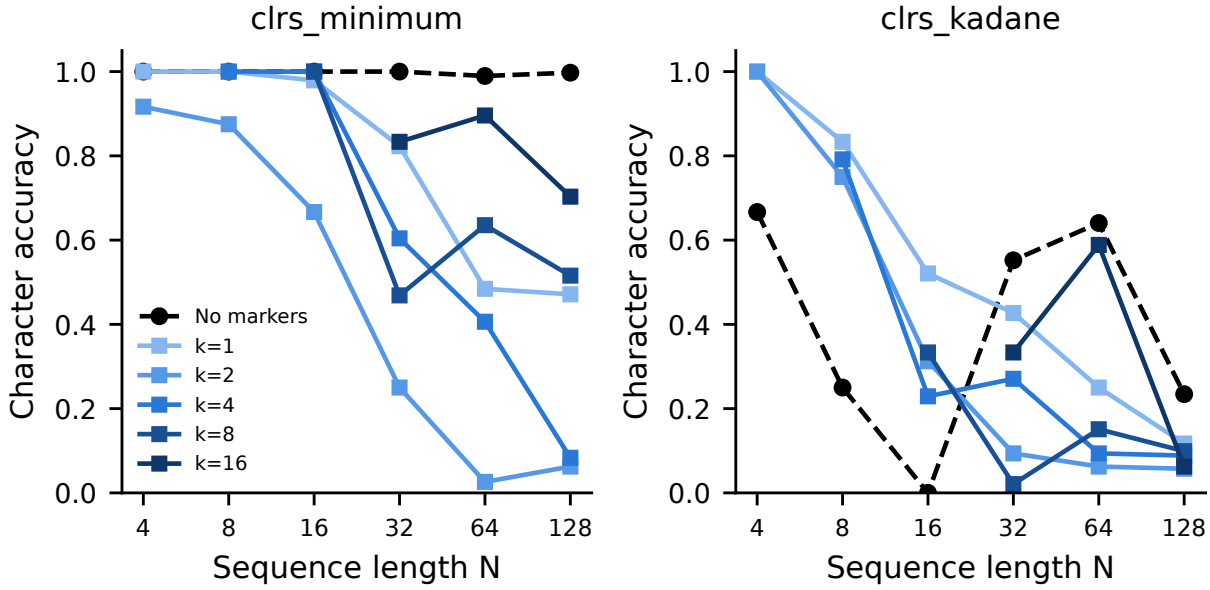



Figure 11: CLRS-Text tasks on Gemini 3.5 Flash by sequence length, one line per marker spacing $k$ (3 trials per cell). Dashed: no markers.

## H Mechanism details

This appendix collects the attention analyses behind Section 7: the mechanism overview (Figure 12), example heads (Figure 13), the earlier head ablation (Figure 14), the head taxonomy (Table 17), and the 7B ablation (Table 16).

Table 16: Head ablation at Qwen2.5-7B, same design as Table 3. Marker gains are small at this scale, so shares are noisy; "–" marks cells with a gain below 0.03.

| | | | | Markers, with heads blocked | | | Share of gain removed | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Format | $N$ | No markers | Markers | Top 10 | Random 10 | Top 10, sham | Top 10 | Controls |
| Letters | 32 | 0.17 | 0.24 | 0.23 | 0.24 | 0.24 | 14% | 0% |
| Letters | 64 | 0.14 | 0.16 | 0.14 | 0.15 | 0.16 | – | – |
| Spaced letters | 32 | 0.42 | 0.55 | 0.51 | 0.52 | 0.55 | 26% | $\leq$ 22% |
| Spaced letters | 64 | 0.19 | 0.30 | 0.27 | 0.31 | 0.32 | 24% | 0% |
| Digits | 32 | 0.24 | 0.27 | 0.28 | 0.29 | 0.28 | – | – |
| Digits | 64 | 0.18 | 0.19 | 0.19 | 0.19 | 0.19 | – | – |

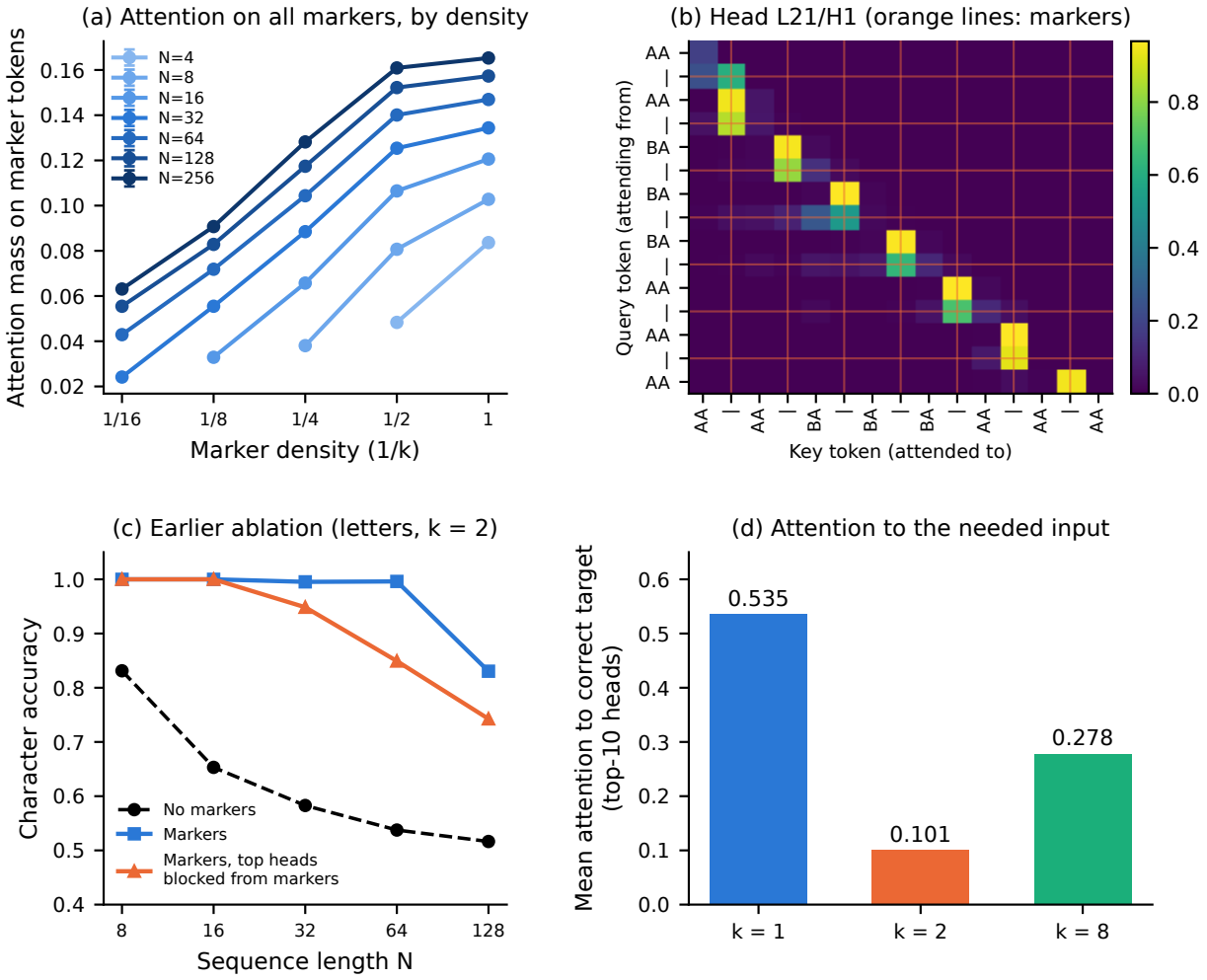



Figure 12: Mechanism (Qwen2.5-32B). (a) Total attention mass on all marker tokens rises with density at every length (`cyclic_shift`, $A = 2$); the number of markers rises faster, so this is not evidence that individual markers draw more attention than content tokens. (b) The most marker-attending head (layer 21, head 1) attends from each position to an adjacent marker. (c) Earlier ablation on contiguous letters ($k = 2$; Section 7): masking the ten most marker-attending heads' attention to markers removes a growing share of the benefit as $N$ grows (0% at $N \leq 16$, 11% at 32, 32% at 64, 28% at 128). (d) `copy_previous` at $N = 32$: mean attention from each output position to the input token it needs (top-10 heads) is 0.535 at $k = 1$, 0.101 at $k = 2$, and 0.278 at $k = 8$, matching accuracy (Base 0.83; $k = 1$: 0.88; $k = 2$: 0.65; $k = 8$: 0.84).

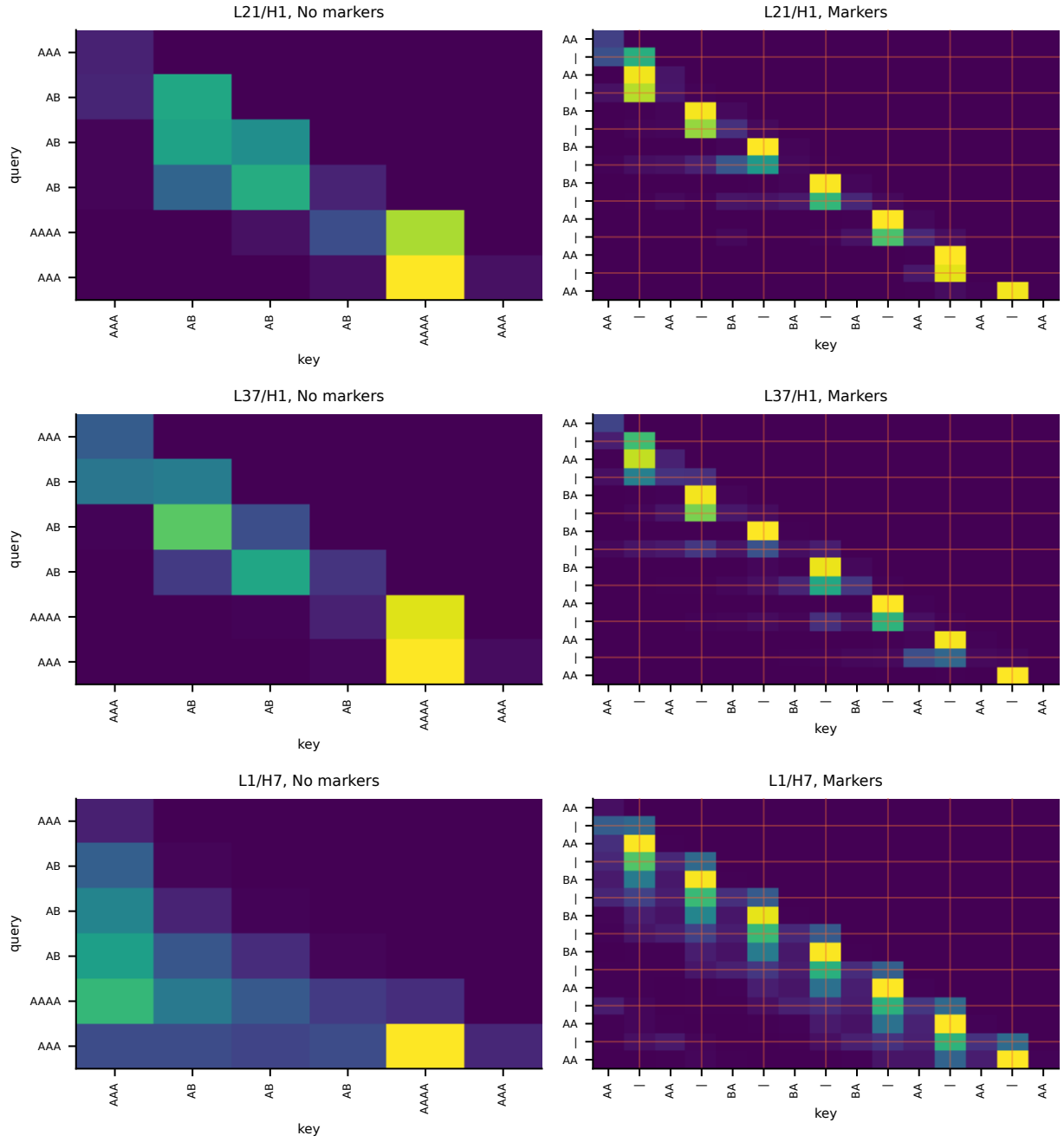



Figure 13: The three most marker-attending heads at Qwen2.5-32B (L21/H1, L37/H1, L1/H7). Without markers, letters merge into multi-character tokens; markers restore per-character resolution.

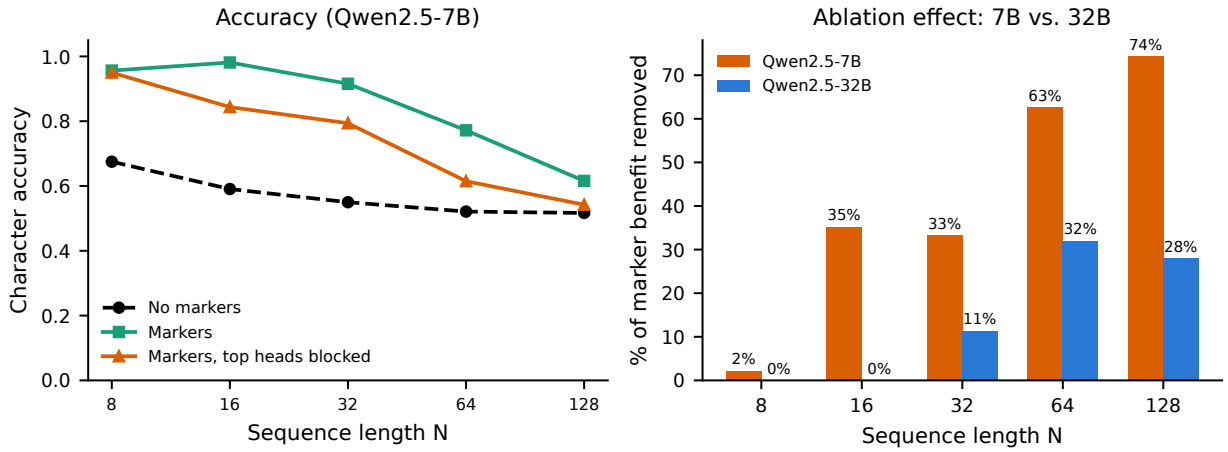



Figure 14: Earlier head ablation, contiguous letters (`cyclic_shift`, $A = 2$, $k = 2$), Qwen2.5-7B and 32B: share of the marker benefit removed by masking the ten most marker-attending heads' attention to markers, re-identified at each length. Unlike Table 3, Base and unablated runs come from an earlier grid and there are no controls at 32B.

Table 17: The ten most marker-attending heads at Qwen2.5-32B, with percentiles within all heads on an induction test and a positional (previous-token) test.

| Layer/Head | Marker attention | Induction pct. | Positional pct. |
|---|---|---|---|
| 21/1 | 0.099 | 38.3 | 98.3 |
| 37/1 | 0.087 | 47.4 | 96.7 |
| 1/7 | 0.086 | 17.1 | 97.7 |
| 35/19 | 0.082 | 23.1 | 96.5 |
| 35/3 | 0.080 | 14.7 | 97.2 |
| 30/32 | 0.079 | 18.6 | 96.0 |
| 32/37 | 0.075 | 14.3 | 98.8 |
| 1/8 | 0.072 | 64.8 | 97.7 |
| 32/7 | 0.071 | 60.4 | 90.2 |
| 19/19 | 0.068 | 9.9 | 83.9 |
| Mean | | 30.9 | 95.3 |

## I Marker ablations

Tables 18–20 vary the marker symbol, its placement, and the prompt wording on contiguous-letter `cyclic_shift` (Section 8).

Table 18: Marker identity, reserved token, and token budget (`cyclic_shift`, $A = 2$, periodic $k = 4$ unless noted). Character accuracy. Budget-matched: `<|>` at $k = 12$ uses the same total tokens as `|` at $k = 4$.

| $N$ | Model | Base | `\|` | `;` | `#` | Reserved token | `<\|>`, $k = 12$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 8 | 7B | 0.675 | 0.717 | 0.792 | 0.792 | 0.469 | 0.675 |
| | 32B | 0.831 | 0.892 | 0.942 | 0.908 | 0.525 | 0.806 |
| 16 | 7B | 0.591 | 0.825 | 0.750 | 0.667 | 0.216 | 0.591 |
| | 32B | 0.653 | 0.896 | 0.846 | 0.912 | 0.284 | 0.759 |
| 32 | 7B | 0.550 | 0.679 | 0.769 | 0.585 | 0.092 | 0.539 |
| | 32B | 0.583 | 0.848 | 0.781 | 0.744 | 0.186 | 0.688 |
| 64 | 7B | 0.521 | 0.616 | 0.650 | 0.591 | 0.049 | 0.453 |
| | 32B | 0.537 | 0.759 | 0.658 | 0.693 | 0.160 | 0.710 |
| 128 | 7B | 0.517 | 0.545 | 0.507 | 0.496 | 0.046 | 0.452 |
| | 32B | 0.516 | 0.694 | 0.744 | 0.561 | 0.219 | 0.642 |

Table 19: Placement regularity (`cyclic_shift`, $A = 2$, marker count matched to $k = 4$). Character accuracy.

| | Qwen2.5-7B | | | | | Qwen2.5-32B | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $N$ | Base | Periodic | ±1 | ±2 | Random | Base | Periodic | ±1 | ±2 | Random |
| 8 | 0.675 | 0.717 | 0.581 | 0.675 | 0.633 | 0.831 | 0.892 | 0.869 | 0.912 | 0.858 |
| 16 | 0.591 | 0.825 | 0.572 | 0.566 | 0.583 | 0.653 | 0.896 | 0.863 | 0.787 | 0.733 |
| 32 | 0.550 | 0.679 | 0.572 | 0.509 | 0.552 | 0.583 | 0.848 | 0.847 | 0.745 | 0.779 |
| 64 | 0.521 | 0.616 | 0.502 | 0.491 | 0.491 | 0.537 | 0.759 | 0.731 | 0.732 | 0.682 |
| 128 | 0.517 | 0.545 | 0.493 | 0.471 | 0.452 | 0.516 | 0.694 | 0.691 | 0.695 | 0.583 |

Table 20: Prompt wording (`cyclic_shift`, $A = 2$, $k = 4$, 15 trials per cell). $\Delta$ = Bounds − Base character accuracy.

| | Qwen2.5-7B, $N =$ | | | | | Qwen2.5-32B, $N =$ | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Wording | 8 | 16 | 32 | 64 | 128 | 8 | 16 | 32 | 64 | 128 |
| Formal | +.09 | +.27 | +.10 | +.13 | +.07 | +.26 | +.17 | +.17 | +.20 | +.18 |
| Casual | −.04 | +.08 | +.12 | +.04 | +.10 | +.08 | +.25 | +.17 | +.21 | +.20 |
| Terse cipher | −.07 | +.08 | +.00 | +.00 | +.05 | −.12 | −.11 | +.01 | −.07 | −.05 |

## J Delimiters, longer sequences, sampling, larger state spaces, and the instruction-based 2×2

Table 21 is the input/output-marker 2×2 as first run, with the format requested in the prompt rather than enforced (Section 7.1).

Table 22 gives the follow-up experiment with commas and line breaks as markers and sequences up to $N = 256$, and Table 23 repeats three tasks with sampling instead of greedy decoding (Sections 5 and 6).

Table 21: Input markers, output markers, or both (Qwen2.5-32B; $N \in \{32, 64\}$, $k \in \{4, 16\}$ pooled, 20 trials per cell). Change is against "Marker sentence, no markers", the baseline used throughout the paper; ± is a 95% interval over generations. "Followed" is the share of generations whose output carried markers exactly as the prompt asked (none, or at the requested offsets); it is n/a where the main grid did not store the raw generations. Post-marker is accuracy at the position right after a marker, which exists only where the input carries markers (chance is 0.5 on `running_xor` and 0.125 on `random_permutation`).

| | | Markers | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | Condition | Input | Output | Accuracy | Change | Followed | Post-marker |
| `running_xor` | No marker sentence | no | no | 0.70 ± 0.03 | +0.04 | 100% | — |
| | Marker sentence, no markers | no | no | 0.66 ± 0.03 | — | n/a | — |
| | Markers in input only | yes | no | 0.65 ± 0.03 | −0.01 | 72% | 0.52 |
| | Markers in output only | no | yes | 0.62 ± 0.02 | −0.04 | 54% | — |
| | Markers in input and output | yes | yes | 0.77 ± 0.02 | +0.11 | n/a | 0.51 |
| `random_permutation (digits)` | No marker sentence | no | no | 0.57 ± 0.07 | +0.02 | 100% | — |
| | Marker sentence, no markers | no | no | 0.55 ± 0.06 | — | 100% | — |
| | Markers in input only | yes | no | 0.76 ± 0.06 | +0.22 | 38% | 0.72 |
| | Markers in output only | no | yes | 0.56 ± 0.04 | +0.01 | 0% | — |
| | Markers in input and output | yes | yes | 0.92 ± 0.03 | +0.37 | 94% | 0.90 |

Table 22: Delimiter type and longer sequences at Qwen2.5-32B ($k \in \{4, 16\}$ pooled, 20 trials per cell; `random_permutation` with digits at $A = 8$, `running_sum_local` at modulus 4). Change in accuracy: marker run minus no-marker run, pooled over positions. Post-marker and within-segment: marker run minus the no-marker run at the same positions. Each delimiter is named in its own constraint sentence. The `|` cells at $N = 64$ reproduce the main grid exactly (same prompts, greedy decoding). No output reached the generation budget.

| | | Change in accuracy | | | Post-marker | | | Within-segment | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task | $N$ | \| | , | line break | \| | , | line break | \| | , | line break |
| `random_permutation (digits)` | 64 | +0.52 | +0.52 | +0.53 | +0.56 | +0.56 | +0.53 | +0.52 | +0.52 | +0.53 |
| | 128 | +0.59 | +0.57 | +0.59 | +0.67 | +0.64 | +0.65 | +0.58 | +0.56 | +0.58 |
| | 256 | +0.46 | +0.46 | +0.47 | +0.53 | +0.53 | +0.50 | +0.46 | +0.45 | +0.46 |
| `running_xor` | 64 | +0.15 | +0.16 | +0.17 | −0.13 | −0.11 | −0.14 | +0.20 | +0.21 | +0.24 |
| | 128 | +0.18 | +0.13 | +0.21 | −0.03 | −0.05 | −0.04 | +0.22 | +0.16 | +0.26 |
| | 256 | +0.17 | +0.15 | +0.20 | +0.04 | +0.03 | +0.05 | +0.19 | +0.17 | +0.23 |
| `running_sum_local` | 64 | +0.13 | +0.11 | +0.15 | −0.13 | −0.11 | −0.12 | +0.17 | +0.15 | +0.19 |
| | 128 | +0.11 | +0.09 | +0.14 | +0.02 | +0.00 | +0.02 | +0.14 | +0.11 | +0.17 |
| | 256 | +0.08 | +0.07 | +0.12 | +0.03 | +0.02 | +0.05 | +0.09 | +0.09 | +0.14 |

Table 23: Sampling instead of greedy decoding at Qwen2.5-32B ($N \in \{32, 64\}$, $k \in \{4, 16\}$ pooled, 20 prompts per cell, one sample each; `random_permutation` at $A = 8$, `running_sum_local` at modulus 4). The greedy rows are the main-grid runs on the same prompts. Change: marker run minus the no-marker run of the same length and trial, with a 95% interval. Post-marker and within-segment: marker run minus the no-marker run of the same decoding regime at the same positions.

| Task | Decoding | No markers | Markers | Change | Post-marker | Within-segment |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| `random_permutation (digits)` | Greedy | 0.55 | 0.92 | +0.37 ± 0.05 | — | — |
| | $T = 0.7$, top-$p$ 0.8 | 0.54 | 0.92 | +0.38 ± 0.05 | — | — |
| | $T = 1.0$, top-$p$ 0.95 | 0.52 | 0.93 | +0.42 ± 0.05 | — | — |
| `running_xor` | Greedy | 0.66 | 0.77 | +0.11 ± 0.03 | −0.18 | +0.16 |
| | $T = 0.7$, top-$p$ 0.8 | 0.67 | 0.76 | +0.09 ± 0.03 | −0.16 | +0.14 |
| | $T = 1.0$, top-$p$ 0.95 | 0.66 | 0.76 | +0.10 ± 0.03 | −0.17 | +0.15 |
| `running_sum_local` | Greedy | 0.39 | 0.48 | +0.09 ± 0.03 | −0.04 | +0.12 |
| | $T = 0.7$, top-$p$ 0.8 | 0.39 | 0.47 | +0.08 ± 0.03 | −0.06 | +0.12 |
| | $T = 1.0$, top-$p$ 0.95 | 0.39 | 0.47 | +0.08 ± 0.03 | −0.07 | +0.11 |